

פרשת במדבר – תשע"ט

SHIUR NOTES ♦ RABBI SHALOM ROSNER

Parshas Bamidbar

A shiur by Rabbi Shalom Rosner ♦ 5779

Sefer Bamidbar opens in the desert — *hefker*, ownerless, belonging to no one. Yet within that formlessness the Torah commands the most meticulous order: every tribe counted, every camp positioned, every flag raised in its precise place. This tension — between wilderness and structure, anonymity and identity, exile and belonging — is the animating spirit of the entire sefer, and the thread Rabbi Rosner traces through six unforgettable teachings.

THEME 1

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Every Sefer Has Its Own Soul

כָּל סֵפֶר יֵשׁ לוֹ עֲנִיָּן בְּפָנָיו עֲצֻמוֹ,
עֲצֻמוֹת וְתַכְלִית מִיּוֹחֶדֶת.

“Every sefer has its own essence, its own unique purpose.”

Rishonim on the structure of the Five Books

The Rishonim each offer a distinct lens through which to read Bamidbar. It is *Chumash HaPekudim* — the Book of Countings — but the census is far from a bureaucratic exercise. Each count is an act of love: Hashem pausing to look at each person individually, to say *you matter, you are known, you are counted*. The sefer spans from year one to year forty of the desert years, with nearly thirty-eight years passing in near-silence between Parshas Chukas and the return of the narrative. That silence is not an absence — it is a canvas. The desert does not hurry. Bamidbar teaches us that formation takes time, and that the years in which nothing seems to happen are often the years in which everything is shaped.

“Bamidbar is the sefer of the in-between — between Egypt and Eretz Yisrael, between revelation and fulfilment. To live in the in-between with faith and structure: that is the challenge of the midbar, and the challenge of our lives.”

Shiur notes prepared by Matthew Miller ◊ TheOtherMatthewMiller.com

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Bitachon Unlocks Torah

מִדַּת הַבְּטָחוֹן מְבִיאָה לְהַבִּינַת הַתּוֹרָה.

“The quality of trust in Hashem brings one to the understanding of Torah.”

Darkei Mussar

The *Darkei Mussar* teaches something that surprises the rational mind: the gateway to deep Torah understanding is not intellectual effort alone, but *bitachon* — genuine, lived trust in Hashem. Torah cannot be acquired by the intellect alone. Hashem must open the gates.

The midbar is the school of bitachon. Stripped of every material crutch — no agriculture, no permanent shelter, no predictable source of water — Bnei Yisrael had only the pillar of cloud by day and fire by night. Their daily bread was manna; their address was wherever Hashem’s presence rested. In this radical dependence, Torah became accessible in a way it never could in the comfort of Egypt.

The lesson for every generation: come to Torah not with your cleverness but with your *emunas chachamim*, your openness, your trust. The gates open from the inside.

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Order Within the Wilderness

הַמִּפְקָד הוּא בִּיטוּיוֹ הַמִּבְהָק
שֶׁל אֲרָגוֹן וְסֹדֶר –
אִישׁ עַל מַחֲנֵהוּ וְאִישׁ עַל דָּגְלוֹ.

“Each man at his camp, each man by his flag. (Bamidbar 2:2)”

Bamidbar 2:2

Midbar in Hebrew shares its root with *hefker*: ownerless, unclaimed, formless. It is the anti-camp. Yet the very first command Hashem gives in *Bamidbar* is to count — to give everyone a number, a name, a tribe, a position. *Ish al machaneiHU ve'ish al diglo*. Each person has a place; each tribe has a location.

This is the Torah's answer to the wilderness: not to escape it, but to bring sacred structure into it. To plant a flag in the sand and say: *here is where I belong*. The census is not about statistics. It is about the radical theological claim that in Hashem's eyes, not a single person is anonymous. Every number in *Sefer Bamidbar* is a name.

“To have order in hefkerus. To be in a makom hefker — a place of ownerlessness — and yet be mufkad: counted, known, placed. That is the spiritual achievement Bamidbar asks of us.”

Flags Like Angels — Love Made Visible

חֶבֶה גְּדוֹלָה חֶבֶב
הַקְּדוֹשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא
שֶׁעָשָׂאם דְּגָלִים כְּמַלְאָכֵי הַשָּׁרִת,
כְּדִי שִׁיהוּ נִכְרִים.

“Great was the love with which the Holy One loved them — giving them flags like the ministering angels — so that they would be recognized.”

Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah 2

Why flags? A flag is a military symbol, a marker of territory. What is it doing in the camp of the Shechinah?

The Midrash finds the answer in Shir HaShirim: *“His banner over me is love”* (2:4).

The flag is not a weapon. It is a declaration of love. Hashem wanted every tribe to be *nikar* — recognizable, distinct, visible. Not uniform, not interchangeable, but each with its own colour, its own symbol, its own genius. The angels are recognizable — Gavriel, Micha’el, Refael, Uriel — each with a role that is uniquely theirs. Hashem honours Bnei Yisrael with the same distinctiveness.

The flags tell each tribe: you are not just part of a mass. You are *you*, and the world needs exactly what you bring — no more, no less.

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No Star Without a Purpose

אֵין כּוֹכַב בְּלֹא מַטָּרָה.

מוֹנֶה מִסְפָּר לְכוֹכָבִים –
לְכָלם שְׁמוֹת יִקְרָא.

“He counts the number of the stars — to each of them He gives a name.”

Tehillim 147:4

Tehillim 147 tells us that Hashem counts the stars and calls each one by name. The same language the Torah uses for the census of Bnei Yisrael. Rabbi Rosner draws the parallel: just as no star exists without a purpose — each one placed in its precise orbit, contributing to the structure of the cosmos — so too every Jew has an unrepeatable, irreplaceable mission.

Some people excel in *tefillah*; some in Torah learning; some in *chesed*; some in kindness to one person at one moment in time. None of these are interchangeable. The world is not a field of identical soldiers. It is a night sky.

“The second we were born was when Hashem decided the world cannot exist without us anymore. Before we were born, the world could manage. The moment we arrived — something changed. The world now needs us.”

This is the deepest reading of the census. Each person counted is not a number. Each number is a name. Each name is a world.

The Silence of the Sdei Chemed

הַכּוֹבֵשׁ אֶת פִּיו
זוֹכֶה לְסִיעֻתָּא דְשָׁמַיָא
בְּלִמּוּדוֹ.

“One who conquers his mouth merits divine assistance in his learning.”

Attributed to the Sdei Chemed

Rabbi Yechiel Michel Epstein (1829–1908), later known as the *Aruch HaShulchan*, records a story about the young Chizkiyahu Medini — who would become the *Sdei Chemed* (1834–1905), one of the great halachic authorities of his generation. As a young scholar in Bukhara, he was falsely accused of something he did not do. He had every right to defend himself; the truth was on his side.

He chose silence.

Not defeat — silence. *Mevater*: to yield what is rightfully yours as an act of spiritual courage. From that moment, his Torah learning soared. The *siyas d'Shmaya* — the divine assistance — that had been waiting for an opening, found one in his restraint.

The lesson Rabbi Rosner draws for our lives: there are moments when the greatest *zechus* we can bring to our Torah is not a brilliant argument, but a closed mouth and an open heart.

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וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֶל-מֹשֶׁה בְּמִדְבַּר סִינַי

“And Hashem spoke to Moshe in the Wilderness of Sinai.”

Bamidbar 1:1 — the opening verse of the sefer

Torah was given in the wilderness — *midbar* — for a reason. The Rabbis teach that Torah belongs to anyone who makes herself *hefker* — open, ownerless, ready to receive. Just as the desert belongs to no tribe and all tribes, Torah is the inheritance of every Jew who comes to it with openness and humility.

Parshas Bamidbar is an invitation to bring that spirit into our own lives: to be counted, to be known, to find our place in the camp — and to carry our flag with love.

About these notes. These shiur notes were prepared by Matthew Miller from the audio recording of Rabbi Shalom Rosner’s shiur on Parshas Bamidbar, 5779. They are a study aid intended to preserve and share the teachings — not a verbatim transcript. Timestamps reference the original audio recording *Bamidbar 5779.mp3*.
